

UNIVERSITY OF PISA

COMPUTER ENGINEERING



I²C Writing Master

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Chapter 1

Introduction

The I²C is a serial communication protocol used to attach lower-speed peripheral ICs to processors and micro-controllers in short-distance and intra-board communication. As reported in Randall Hyde's book [1], before I²C bus, different components of a computer system communicated with one another using 8 to 32 data lines and some number of address signals, requiring more space and increasing the amount of noise to deal with. In 1982 [2], Philips Semiconductors (now NXP Semiconductors) developed the I²C protocol, alleviating these problems using just 2 wires: the data line (SDA) and the clock line (SCL).

1.1 Circuit description

The system is composed of one or more masters, that can write or read, and several slaves, all connected to the bus, with a bidirectional communication. Typical implementation is shown in Figure 1.1:

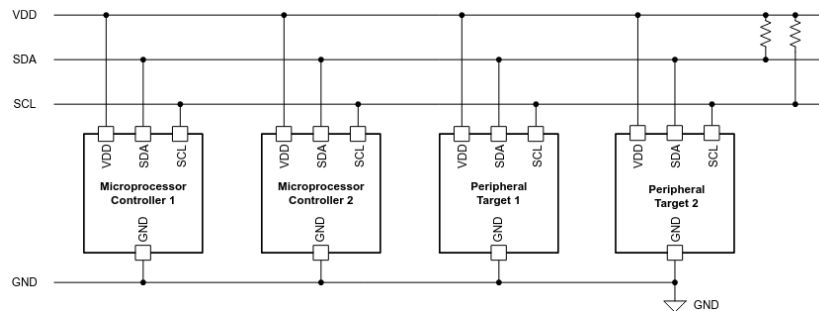


Figure 1.1: I²C implementation [2].

1.2 Possible applications

The I²C protocol is widely adopted in embedded systems, thanks to the low power consumption and space optimization, to interface microcontrollers with various peripheral ICs, such as sensors, execution elements and human interaction devices. One example is presented in [3], where the protocol is used to connect a master, the embedded computer, to all the devices installed for a smart home.

1.3 Writing Master

One possible implementation is the one reported in this documentation: the Writing Master. The device acts as the master in the I²C protocol, but can only write data; no reading operation is implemented. The design is shown in Figure 1.2:

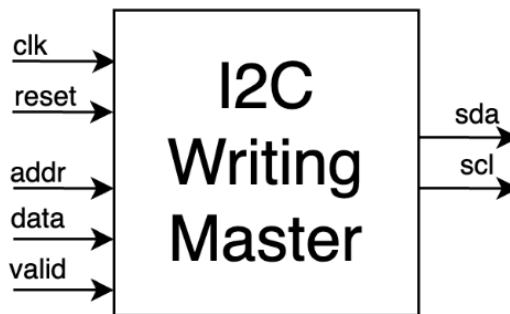


Figure 1.2: Writing Master design

The system is synchronized by a global clock (**clk**) and initialized by an active-low asynchronous **reset**. All the signals in input to the Writing Master come from a processor or a microcontroller to indicate when to communicate, using the **valid** signal, to whom, providing the 7-bit **addr** signal, and what, using the 8-bit **data** signal. After receiving the essential information, the master starts to communicate with the slave indicated in the **addr** signal using the **scl** and **sda** signals. The **sda** signal is used by the slave too during the acknowledgment phase. The clock used to communicate with the slave is 32 times slower than the system clock (**clk** signal). A possible use case of this implementation is with actuators or display drivers, for example, where the master sends a command and they simply answer with the ACK signal.

Chapter 2

Architecture

The architecture of the Writing Master is characterized by three main components:

- `REG_STATE LOGIC` (synchronous), for updating all the registers, i.e., current state, counters and data;
- `NEXT_STATE LOGIC` (combinatorial), to compute the next state;
- `OUTPUT LOGIC` (combinatorial), to generate the correct signals for the I²C protocol and serialize data.

The following section present the block diagram to show how these components communicate and how the signals are used.

2.1 Block diagram

The Figure 2.1 shows how the three components communicate between them and which signals are used for the logic implementation:

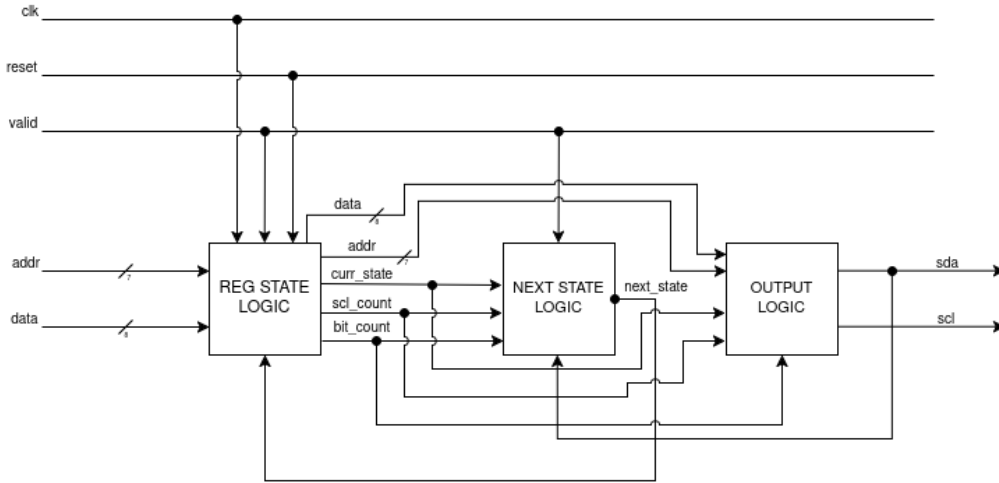


Figure 2.1: Writing Master block diagram

The `REG.STATE LOGIC` is the synchronous block of the architecture. It manages the registers and handles the reset phase (`reset` signal is 0). The `next_state` signal, coming from the `NEXT.STATE LOGIC`, drives the current state register, while the `addr` and `data` signals are sampled only when `valid` is 1. Regarding the counters, the `scl_count` signal is incremented by one at every clock cycle, whereas the `bit_count` signal increments every 32 clock cycles and only during transmission states. The `NEXT.STATE LOGIC` is one of the two combinatorial components and implements the logic to decide the next state where the system will be at the next rising edge of the clock. It needs all the counters to know when the last bit is transmitted and the I²C cycle clock is over. Additionally, it uses the `valid` signal to start a transaction (consecutive or not) and checks `sda` signal to know if the acknowledgement signal is received. The last combinatorial component is the `OUTPUT LOGIC`, which sets the output signals to communicate using the I²C protocol. Based on the `scl_count` signal, it generates a clock 32 times slower than the system clock, while the `bit_count` signal is used to select the correct bit to transmit.

Chapter 3

VHDL

```
1 entity writing_master is
2     -- I/O ports definition
3     port (
4         clk : in std_logic;           -- system clock signal
5         reset : in std_logic;         -- reset signal
6         addr : in std_logic_vector(6 downto 0); -- slave's address
7         data : in std_logic_vector(7 downto 0); -- writing data
8         valid : in std_logic;         -- input validity signal ('1' or '0')
9         sda : inout std_logic;        -- data line for serial communication
10        scl : out std_logic           -- device clock line
11    );
12 end entity;
```

Listing 3.1: Writing Master Entity

Bibliography

- [1] R. Hyde, *The Book of I2C: A Guide for Adventurers*. No Starch Press, 2022.
- [2] J. Wu, “A basic guide to i2c,” *Texas Instruments*, p. 132, 2022.
- [3] L. N. Pintilie, T. Pop, I. C. Gros, and A. M. Iuoras, “An i2c and ethernet based open-source solution for home automation in the iot context,” in *2019 54th International Universities Power Engineering Conference (UPEC)*, IEEE, 2019, pp. 1–4.